

How E-Learning Tools can Foster Intercultural Competence

Gisele L. White

Northern Arizona University

I would like to propose a one-day intercultural workshop using e-learning tools to foster an exchange between college freshmen in Germany studying English (n=15) and college freshmen in Japan studying English (n=15). Both the Japanese and German students must possess an English proficiency level of intermediate or higher. The goals of this workshop are 1. For the Japanese students to share aspects of Japanese culture with their German counterparts 2. Assess their perceptions of German people pre and post-workshop 3. What challenges they encountered communicating in English with non-Japanese students and any strategies they might have used. Assessments of this workshop will consist of recordings of the video chats, to assess communicative strategies used when using English as a lingua franca and comparisons of pre and post workshop questionnaires provided by the instructor, to assess changes in intercultural awareness.

Each Japanese student will begin the workshop by creating and submitting a pre and post-workshop questionnaires, in Moodle, to one student in Germany, to try to get a sense of their German counterpart's ideas and perceptions of Japanese people, Japanese culture, etc. The Japanese students will then read three source culture (Cortazzi & Jin, 1999) articles and discuss them in groups of 3 with their fellow classmates, in English. They will write about their observations of this discussion, in a separate section of Moodle. They will then connect with their German partner, via Skype video chat, and discuss the articles. The use of online dictionaries, concordancers, and translators are optional. They will use Moodle to record any differences or similarities they found in discussing these articles with their German counterparts as opposed to their fellow Japanese classmates. This will include not only the content but also the pragmatic aspects (politeness, directness, suggestions, etc.) of this interaction, communication difficulties, and how they felt about their exchange in general. Finally, each

student will share their Moodle links with their Japanese classmates and German partners. The German students will complete and submit their post-workshop questionnaire, via Moodle.

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Conclusion

Since the participants in both studies were largely of the same mind before and after these courses, neither study really illustrated how e-learning could change one's intercultural awareness. Additionally, the participants' positive feelings towards using a discussion board may also stem from the fact that there were probably not many confrontational forms of intercultural exchange. Neither study reported familiarizing the students with discussion forum etiquette or protocol. The pragmatics of expressing an opinion or disagreeing with someone via an on-line format would have been a relevant addendum to either study.

Implications

How can these studies help us in the classroom? As computer labs in learning institutions become increasingly ubiquitous and each generation of students more technically savvy, teachers can take advantage of these changes to create more authentic intercultural learning experiences. While not mentioned in these studies, the use of video chatting, online virtual museums, and even humble email are being used to bring cultural/global awareness and interaction into the classroom.

The myriad of ways that technology can facilitate intercultural competence have yet to be fully explored. However, these two studies show that there is room for e-learning technology in the classroom and that today's students are prepared to work with it. Technology can't replace critical thought but it can provide an excellent conduit for those thoughts to be exchanged.

References

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